

GOLD AND POWER

The goldsmiths and jewellers of Italy were innovators during the Renaissance, elevating their craft to that of art under the patronage of the powerful de' Medici family, a banking and political dynasty that was established by Cosimo the Elder and effectively ruled Florence from the 15th to the early 18th centuries. The goldsmith's trade incorporated painting and sculpture, and many of the great Renaissance artists emerged from the Medici workshops, including Filippo Brunelleschi, Sandro Botticelli, and Benvenuto Cellini. Francesco I de' Medici, son of Cosimo I and Grand Duke of Tuscany, was especially interested in metalwork and jewellery. He established a workshop in the Uffizi Palace to broaden and develop jewellery-making techniques and the artistry of its practitioners.

Not surprisingly, the Medici crown jewels were renowned throughout Europe. Included in the trousseau of Catherine de' Medici for her marriage to King Henry II of France were pear-shaped pearls among the largest in Europe and a casket inset with engraved rock crystal by gem-cutter Valerio Belli, whose patron was Giovanni de' Medici, the Renaissance Pope Leo X.

**Gold is a treasure,
and he who possesses
it does all he wishes
to in this world**

Christopher **Columbus**

15th-century explorer

The Goldsmiths' Workshop, Alessandro (Il Barbiere) Fei, 1572

Grand Duke of Tuscany and patron of the arts Francesco I de' Medici (far left) inspects his father's crown and other items in a Florentine jewellery workshop.

